AP/POLS 1000 6.0B

Mid-term Exam (take home)

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Question 1:

Democratic systems are based on some combination of 'freedom', 'equality' and 'solidarity'. In what ways does 'solidarity' complicate our understanding of 'freedom' and 'equality'?

Answer 1:

Of the three pillars of democracy solidarity is the most challenging for the purpose of understanding and agreeing on the essence of freedom and equality. History is full of examples where solidarity (the creation of a meaningful obligation between citizens to bind their fate together to a lesser or greater degree for a particular cause) has been a catalyst to advancing democratic movements. The founding fathers' solidarity in the repeal of British rule that led to the creation of the American Republic, The Martin Luther King led Civil Rights movement in the U.S., the Polish Solidarity movement led by Lech Walesa that caused the demise of Communism in Central and Eastern Europe are all perfect examples. Yet solidarity at its core competes with some of the fundamental principles of freedom of thought and expression, equality of access to opportunity and political and economical ascendancy. Taken to an extreme solidarity may lead societies toward socialist transformation in an otherwise capitalistic society when exerted from the bottoms up (e.g. powerful trade unions in the post depression era) and could lead to fascism or totalitarianism when exerted from the top down (e.g. Nazi Germany).

Solidarity is clearly an idealistic concept one that democratic societies may thrive for but one that is hardly attainable in large liberal democracies like the United States or to a lesser degree Canada. The argument is that solidarity has proven to be an effective instrument in incubating "start-up" democratic processes but failed to sustain its effectiveness in larger more established and diverse democracies.

The instinctive human nature of solidarity is most evident when citizens help each other in times of disaster. Cooperation during emergencies is a spontaneous form of solidarity in the name of fairness and justice, an essential ingredient in every democratic society. These are all examples of self imposed solidarity. However when either forced or misdirected as a political instrument it may well infringe on rights of freedom and equality. Two examples are given: As America championed principles of freedom and equality during World War II, it denied fundamental rights to many non-white citizens. Neil Foley a professor of History at the University of Texas in Austin has written about "The Quest for Equality – The failed promise of Black-Brown solidarity". (Foley N., 2006. Harvard University Press) in it he describes how in the wake of President Franklin Roosevelt's "Good Neighbor" policy with Latin America, African American and Mexican American civil rights leaders sought ways to make that policy of respect and mutual obligations apply at home as well as abroad. However they could not reconcile their cultural and political objectives in bringing about the necessary changes. Switzerland conjures up images of an idealistic democratic society best known for its neutrality. Yet in World War II ordinary citizens tried in all ways to protect Jewish refugees against the will of the Swiss state.

In 1973 pointing to the economic crisis at that time the Swiss government refused to accommodate Chilean refugees. A strong solidarity movement in Switzerland resisted the repeat of the WWII example and accommodated the asylum seekers in private homes risking their own freedom and personal security. To this day Federalism in Switzerland continues to undermine solidarity whilst espousing freedom and equality for its people. 6

Question 2:

How would Marxist thought on the state and democracy interpret the political conventions (political practice) of contemporary legislatures within liberal democracies?

Answer 2:

Marxist thought is fundamentally opposed to liberal democracy. It asserts that a capitalistic state cannot by definition be democratic as it is in fact a dictatorship of the bourgeoisie. The belief that political parties are controlled by capitalists who cater to the needs of politicians for financial resources to fund their re-election campaigns. Therefore all political practices are exclusionary in that they leave out and impose restrictions and place obstacles for the average citizen to actively participate in the democracy. On that basis one can immediately understand that Marx followers must be quick to illustrate their viewpoint by examining political practices of contemporary

legislators within liberal democracies such as Canada and the United States. Two examples are given:

a) U.S. Congressional Committees:

When Americans watch their President sign a major bill into law what they see is pomp and ceremony. Few understand the road this bill had to travel before arriving at the President desk for the photo op. The Congressional Committees (or sub-committees) are first to hold hearings, draft legislation debate major policy options and revise or amend the original draft. Committee meetings are usually held behind closed doors away from the public eye. (first point scored for Marxists) This is when special interest groups have the best opportunity to shape, change America's public policy in an attempt to gain advantage for their cause. It is well known that not just through arguments do they achieve their aims but rather through generous campaign donations to members of the committee responsible for the relevant issue (e.g. finance, banking, environment etc.) A Committee Chair is likely the most powerful position in American politics. The "proletariat" is unaware and uninvited (major point scored for Marxists)

b) Canadian Parliament - Question Period:

Question Period is the main instrument by which the opposition parties attempt to keep the government of the day accountable for its policies. Question Period is 45 minutes long and on average every question has a time limit of 35 seconds according to Frances H. Ryan (Ryan F.H. Canadian

Parliamentary Review/Autumn 2009) article titled "Can Question Period Be Reformed?". Because of the intense media attention it receives Question Period has become a school yard antics show where MP's are disguising partisan slogans in a form of questions. Backbenchers are not allowed to ask questions so that their constituents are not properly represented.

Needless to say supporters of liberal democracy would rebut by pointing out that while there may be shortcomings as illustrated, there are no better alternatives and even if there were Marxism is not the one. They point out that liberal democracies seldom if ever go to war with each other. They point to the fact that even poor liberal democracies have better education, longer life expectancy and lower infant mortality than poor dictatorships (e.g. North Korea). Finally they say that while corruption is by no means absent in democracy, the parliamentary systems, political stability and freedom of the press are more effective in curbing government corruption than that which exists in Marxist dictatorships.

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Question 3:

Which of the major electoral systems do you think is most effective in furthering the goals of democracy and why?

Answer 3:

The Single Member Plurality ("SMP") election is the most common and best known electoral system currently in use in America and Canada. In the U.S it is used to elect members to the House of Representatives and many state and local legislatures. In SMP elections the candidate with the most votes (not necessarily a majority) wins the seat in that electoral district. In some countries the system is modified into a Single Member Majority (e.g. Afghanistan) where in the event that neither candidate won a majority of the vote in the first round, the two top vote getters hold a runoff election shortly thereafter to ensure that the winning candidate has the mandate of the majority of voters. The other electoral system is known as Proportional Representation (PR). In PR there is a direct correlation between the percent of votes that a group of candidates (say on a party list like the Israeli Knesset (parliament)) and the percentage of seats up for election (e.g. 120 Knesset members). In order to form an opinion as to which system best furthers the goals of democracy, one needs first recognize the practical consequences of both. First, in SMP because one member is elected the other votes (many time the majority in aggregate) do not count and are literally "wasted" not so in PR where every vote counts. Secondly and likely because of the first reason it has been proven that there is a lower turnout of voters in SMP as compared to PR (by between 4-7 percent according the Commission on Legislative Democracy). Thirdly SMP typically result in under representations of minorities (e.g. women). For example as of December, 2003 the percentage of women MP's in Canada was 21% whereas in the PR electoral system it was 31% in Argentina and

45% in Sweden (source: inter-parliamentary union, Women in National Parliaments www.ipu.org/wmn-e/classif.htm) Finally since it is not necessary to win a majority SMP results in a "minority majority" creating a weak or fragmented opposition which may be viewed as unhealthy for democracy. On the surface it would appear that the PR system upholds more of the principles of democracy. However it is the opinion of the writer that SMP in large well established and economically developed democracies with fewer parties (2 or 3) is preferable for political stability and consistent governance. By contrast PR may well be the preferred system in smaller, evolving progressive democracies without a long history of political lessons. (e.g. Israel) In that model coalition governments are formed, compromises are struck and the majority of diverse opinion properly represented. Except that with democratic maturity the ability to act decisively on existential challenges of the state, it is extremely difficult to create a consensus. This is evident in Israeli politics and may well be the reason why Israel has not come together with a single vision of peace with its Palestinian neighbors, peace that all Israelis almost without exception have been longing for over 60 years.

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FANTASTIC !!

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